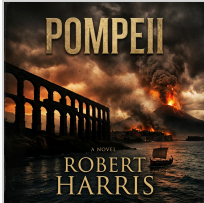


Water and Sanitation Through Time - Guided Reading Extract



Pompeii

By Robert Harris

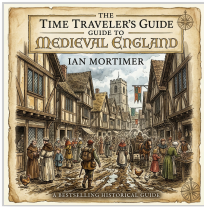
"The aquarius stood on the deck of the liburnian as it cut across the Bay of Naples. The water levels in the great reservoir, the Piscina Mirabilis, had dropped significantly overnight. It was not a breach; it was something far worse. The ground itself, he realised with a sinking feeling, was swelling upwards, tilting the aqueduct off its gradient and choking the flow of life to the towns."

Comprehension & Inference

1. What is the protagonist's job title, and what does it involve?

2. What crucial change in the water levels does the aquarius notice?

3. Why is the ground swelling, and what impact does this have on the aqueduct?



The Time Traveler's Guide to Medieval England

By Ian Mortimer

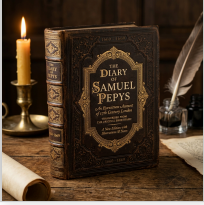
"You walk down the narrow, unpaved street, your boots sinking into a thick, foul-smelling mud. The air is heavy with the stench of woodsmoke, rotting vegetables, and raw sewage. A sudden splash alerts you—someone has just emptied their chamber pot from a second-story window into the open gutter running down the centre of the street. Pigs root through the muck, undisturbed by the noise."

Comprehension & Inference

1. How does the author describe the physical condition of the medieval street?

2. What sensory details (smell, sound, sight) does the author use to make the scene feel real?

3. What does the presence of pigs and the emptying of chamber pots reveal about medieval attitudes toward sanitation?



The Diary of Samuel Pepys

By Samuel Pepys

"Going down into my cellar to look... I stepped into a great heap of turds, by which I found that Mr. Turner's house of office is full and comes into my cellar, which do trouble me, but I shall have it helped... I was forced to call my wife and maids to clean my shoes."

Comprehension & Inference

1. What shocking discovery does Samuel Pepys make in his cellar?

2. What does the phrase 'house of office' refer to in this context?

3. What does this diary entry tell us about the limitations of early modern waste disposal, even for wealthy individuals?



Bleak House

By Charles Dickens

"It is a black, dilapidated street, avoided by all decent people; where the crazy houses were seized upon, when their decay was far advanced, by some bold vagrants... Now, these tumbling tenements contain, by night, a swarm of misery. As on the ruined human wretch, vermin parasites appear, so these ruined shelters have bred a crowd of foul existence that crawls in and out of gaps in walls and boards..."

Comprehension & Inference

1. How does Dickens describe the physical condition of the houses in this slum?

2. What metaphor does Dickens use to describe the people living in these tenements?

3. Why might a historian find this fictional description useful for understanding the causes of cholera?



Letter to The Times on the Condition of the Thames

By Michael Faraday

"I tore up some white cards into pieces, moistened them so as to make them sink easily below the surface, and then dropped some of these pieces into the water at every pier the boat came to; before they had sunk an inch below the surface they were indistinguishable... The smell was very bad... the whole river was for the time a real sewer."

Comprehension & Inference

1. Describe the simple experiment Michael Faraday conducted from the boat.

2. What were the results of his experiment, and what did it prove about the water?

3. Why would a letter from a highly respected scientist like Faraday be more effective than a complaint from an ordinary citizen?
